

LITERATURE REVIEW

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What do we have so far before embarking on the literature review?

Field of research

Research idea

Research aim

A few introductory paragraphs

What is a literature review?

- A piece of academic writing demonstrating knowledge and understanding of the academic literature on a specific topic placed in context.
- It is a process of reviewing work of others within your field, and using that as a basis for your data collection.
- Generally, prepared to put a research problem in context or to identify gaps and weaknesses in prior studies to justify a new investigation.
- Generally, forms a section or part of a dissertation, research project, journal article, or long essay.

“...your task is to build an argument, not a library.”

(Rudestam and Newton, 1992)

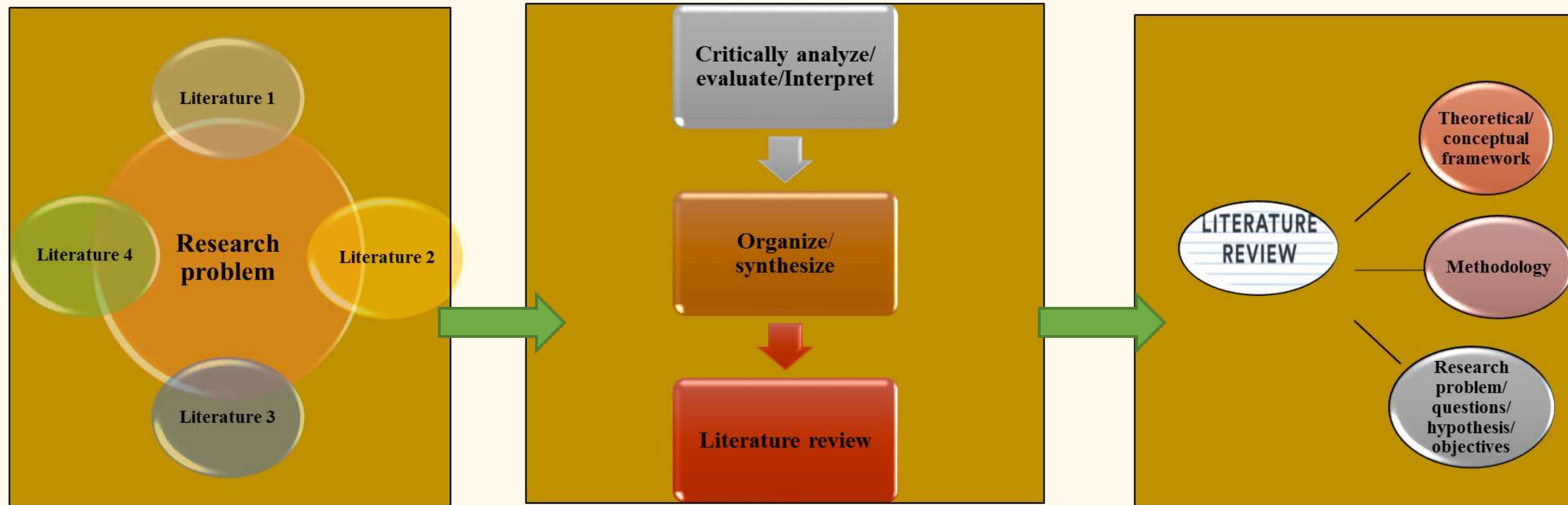
The two main objectives of a literature review;

- content covering existing research, theories and evidence
 - your own critical evaluation and discussion of this content
- before carrying out a new investigation.

When doing and writing a literature review, it is good practice to:

- summarize and analyze previous research and theories;
- identify areas of controversy and contested claims;
- highlight any gaps that may exist in research to date.

Let's understand the literature review structure in this sketch



Purpose of a literature review

- Broadens your knowledge on a topic
- Shows your skill at finding relevant information
- Allows for critical appraisal of research
- Position your own research within the context of existing literature
- Establish theoretical or conceptual framework/ create theories
- Identify areas of prior scholarship to prevent duplication of effort
- Identify research gaps/ unanswered questions
- Support research methodology and design
- Enhance credibility
- Guiding research question/ hypotheses

Literature review types

Narrative reviews

Systematic reviews

Meta-analysis reviews

Scoping reviews



- Allow researchers to describe what is known on a topic while conducting a subjective examination and critique of an entire body of literature

- Often useful for topics that require a meaningful synthesis of research evidence that may be complex or broad and that require detailed, nuanced description and interpretation

- No hard and fast rules

**Narrative
reviews**

- Use explicit and transparent methods, and follow a standard set of stages
- Uses PRISMA model
- Accountable, replicable and updateable
- Appraise the validity of the results and findings of the collected studies in an impartial way
- Define clear objectives and reproducible methodologies
- Usually involves more than one person to increase objectivity and trustworthiness
- Peer-reviewed and published or registered in a suitable repository to help avoid duplication of reviews, and for comparisons to be made with the final review and the planned review
- Used in research and policymaking to inform evidence-based decisions and practice

Systematic reviews

Sections of a Systematic Review Manuscript

Title	Describe your manuscript and state whether it is a systematic review, meta-analysis, or both.
Abstract	Structure the abstract and include (as applicable): background, objectives, data sources, study eligibility criteria, participants, interventions, quality assessment and synthesis methods, results, limitations, conclusions, implications of key findings, and systematic review registration number.
Introduction	Describe the rationale for the review and provide a statement of questions being addressed.
Methods	Include details regarding the protocol, eligibility criteria, databases searched, full search strategy of at least one database (often reported in appendix), and the study selection process. Describe how data were extracted and analyzed. If a librarian is part of your research team, that person may be best suited to write this section.
Results	Report the numbers of articles screened at each stage using a PRISMA diagram. Include information about included study characteristics, risk of bias (quality assessment) within studies, and results across studies.
Discussion	Summarize main findings, including the strength of evidence and limitations of the review. Provide a general interpretation of the results and implications for future research.
Funding	Describe any sources of funding for the systematic review.
Appendix	Include entire search strategy for at least one database in the appendix (include search strategies for all databases searched for more transparency).

Refer to the [PRISMA checklist](#) for more information.

- Provides a quantitative estimate for intervention or exposure
- Combine statistical results from existing studies
- May also be qualitative and reveal the biases, strengths, and weaknesses of existing studies, and can be used to form recommendations or to provide guidance in the design of future clinical trials/ research
- Can help iron out any inconsistencies in data, as long as the studies are similar, and thus help improve precision about evidence, and make it possible to eventually reach new hypotheses and explore the reasons for controversy
- Answer questions with a broader influence than individual studies

Meta-analysis reviews

- Aims to identify the nature and extent of research evidence (usually including ongoing research)
- Examining emerging evidence when specific questions are unclear - clarify definitions and conceptual boundaries
- Include different types of literature and cast a wide net for mapping the existing literature
- A scoping review is done prior to a systematic review
- Not necessarily identify hypotheses
- Offer the opportunity to engage stakeholders in the review process

Scoping reviews

Main activities in the Lit. Review

01

Identifying research
question

02

Choosing search terms
(Concept map)

03

Identifying other keywords
(synonyms, broad terms,
narrow terms etc.)

04

Formulation of search
strategy

05

Selecting relevant sources

06

Conducting your search/
Literature search

07

Applying practical
screening criteria

08

Evaluation of the search
process

09

Evaluation of the search
results/ Literature

10

Write down the literature
review by synthesizing the
results

Points to consider in literature review

What you can look for in literature;

- Policies
- Theories
- Concepts
- Procedures
- Methodologies
- Quantitative and qualitative research data
(e.g. interviews, observations, surveys,
statistics)
- Further references

Scope

- Research question
 - Time period
- Goals/ relevance/ level
- Geographical scope
- Specific discipline
- Type of publication
- References

Points to consider in literature review

Reflect SMART Model

formulation of clear and effective research objectives or goals



Organizing principle

It should have a single organizing principle;

- Thematic - organize around a topic or issue
- Chronological - sections for each vital time period
- Methodological - focus on the methods used by the researchers/writers

A final checklist

- Have you indicated the purpose of the review?
- Have you emphasized recent developments?
- Is there a logic to the way you organized the material?
- Does the amount of detail included on an issue, related to its importance?
- Have you been sufficiently critical of design and methodological issues?
- Have you indicated when results were conflicting or inconclusive and discussed possible reasons?
- Has your summary of the current literature contributed to the reader's understanding of the problems?

Recommended reading/ video tutorials for further study

- Brodsky, M. (n.d.). *Steps in the literature review process*. In *LibGuides: Literature reviews*. University of Texas Libraries. Retrieved May 30, 2024, from <https://guides.lib.utexas.edu/c.php?g=1060589&p=7710319>
- Bond, L. (2012, April 19). *Literature review: Getting started*. Learning Lab. Retrieved May 30, 2024, from <https://learninglab.rmit.edu.au/content/literature-review-overview>
- Paré, G., & Kitsiou, S. (2017). Methods for literature reviews. In *Handbook of eHealth evaluation: An evidence-based approach*. University of Victoria. Retrieved May 30, 2024, from <https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK481583/>

Adapted from these material available online

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Mak, S., & Thomas, A. (2022). An introduction to scoping reviews. *Journal of Graduate Medical Education*, 14(5), 561–564. Retrieved May 27, 2024, from <https://doi.org/10.4300/JGME-D-22-00620.1>

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